Cheatsheet · 19 chapters on one page

Natural Language Processing cheatsheet

Every formula, key idea, table, memory aid and common mistake from the chapters, gathered in one place for quick revision. Nothing here is new. Each card links back to the lesson that teaches it, so open the lesson when a line does not make sense yet.

93 key ideas | 99 formulas | 65 tables | 46 tips and traps

STEP 1 Language and meaning

1.1 What language is

The working definition, six levels from phonetics to pragmatics, symbols and the semiotic triangle, the speaker and hearer chain, Zipf and Grice, and recursion.

KEY IDEAS

- **Working definition** Language is a systematic, symbolic and structured system that starts as thought, organises it, and lets it be rebuilt in another mind.
- **Six levels** Phonetics, phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics. Each combines the units of the level below.
- **Two functions** Symbolic: words stand for concepts, not directly for things (semiotic triangle). Interactive: a speaker encodes and a hearer reconstructs, never an exact copy.
- **Form and meaning** A symbol is a conventional form meaning pair. Unicorn has a sense without a reference. TAM marks present, past and imagined reality.
- **Effort and clarity** Zipf: least effort, f(r) ≈ C ÷ r. Grice: quantity, quality, relation, manner.
- **Recursion** A clause inside a clause without limit. Everett claimed Pirahã lacks it, a challenge to Hauser, Chomsky and Fitch. Still debated.

FORMULAS

Working definition from the lecture

Exam favourite

Language is a **systematic, symbolic and structured** system that (1) starts as thought in the mind, (2) organises chaotic ideas into structure, and (3) lets those ideas be sent out, carried and rebuilt in another mind.

Every later topic in this course, from tokens to parse trees, is a way of recovering some part of this structure from text.

Lesson: What language is

The key claim Exam favourite

Language does not directly represent the external world. It represents our **conceptualised experience** of the world.

Say "leopard" in a classroom. No leopard appears, yet everyone understands, because the word calls up a concept that speaker and listener already share.

Lesson: The symbolic function: words stand for concepts

The communication chain Exam favourite

Thought → linguistic representation → signal → linguistic representation → reconstructed thought

The first and last boxes are different. Communication never copies a thought. It only gives the hearer enough to rebuild an approximation.

Lesson: The interactive function: from one mind to another

Zipf: least effort

$$f(r) \approx \frac{C}{r^{\alpha}}, \alpha \approx 1$$

A few short words such as "the" are used constantly. Thousands of rare words are kept for precision. Chapter 3.1 measures this on real text.

Lesson: The interactive function: from one mind to another

Grice: the cooperative principle

Quantity, Quality, Relation, Manner

Say enough but not too much, be truthful, be relevant, be clear. Breaking a maxim on purpose creates an implied meaning.

Lesson: The interactive function: from one mind to another

TABLES

Table: question · what it needs · where it leads

Question	What it needs	Where it leads
How do I manipulate this string of words?	String operations, patterns, counts and probabilities	Statistical NLP: n-gram models, classifiers and today the next word prediction of large language models
What kind of system could produce this behaviour?	A theory of the representations and rules inside a mind or machine	Symbolic NLP, formal grammars and the cognitive science side of linguistics

Lesson: What language is

Table: level · unit studied · question it answers · example

Level	Unit studied	Question it answers	Example
Phonetics	Raw speech sounds	How are sounds produced, carried and heard?	[k] is made by stopping air at the back of the mouth with no voice
Phonology	Phonemes, the sound system	Which sound differences change meaning in this language?	/p/ against /b/ turns "pat" into "bat"
Morphology	Words and word parts	How are words built from meaningful parts?	dis + taste = distaste
Syntax	Phrases and sentences	How do words combine into sentences?	"The cat jumped" is subject then verb
Semantics	Literal meaning	What does the sentence mean on its own?	"The cat jumped" names a jumping event done by a cat
Pragmatics	Meaning in context	What does the speaker intend here and now?	"I sat near a bank": river or money?

Lesson: The six levels of linguistic structure

Table: reality · example from the lecture · how grammar marks it

Reality	Example from the lecture	How grammar marks it
Present	The cat is sleeping.	Present tense with progressive aspect (is + verb + ing)
Past	The cat was sleeping.	Past tense with progressive aspect (was + verb + ing)
Imagined	Imagine a cat flying over the moon.	Irrealis mood, signalled by "imagine"
Abstract	Justice is important.	A property turned into a noun with no physical referent

Lesson: The symbolic function: words stand for concepts

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER

Structure creates meaning. "Dog bites man" and "man bites dog" use the same three words. A bag of words model that ignores order cannot tell them apart, which is why later chapters bother with tags, n-grams and parse trees.

Lesson: What language is

COMMON MISTAKE Listeners usually also infer "if it does not rain, I will go", which the logic does not say. This gap between logical form and everyday meaning is one reason formal logic alone could not solve language understanding.

Lesson: The symbolic function: words stand for concepts

IN THE EXAM In an essay, link Zipf to the speaker side (minimise effort) and Grice to the shared contract between both sides.

Lesson: The interactive function: from one mind to another

1.2 Ambiguity: why language is hard for machines

Lexical against structural ambiguity, the Lesk method, PP attachment, Catalan growth of parse trees and how machines resolve ambiguity.

KEY IDEAS

- **Two kinds** Lexical: one word, several meanings (bank, over). Structural: one string, several trees (telescope).
- **Word types** Homonymy (unrelated meanings), polysemy (related senses), homophones (same sound), homographs (same spelling).
- **Lesk** Pick the sense whose gloss shares most words with the context. A counting version of Firth.
- **Catalan growth** A verb, object and k prepositional phrases have C(k + 1) trees: 2, 5, 14, 42, 132.
- **Resolution** Rules (right association), treebank statistics (lexical association), contextual neural models. Ask when the cost of a wrong guess is high.
- **Lecture examples** I sat near a bank. The cat jumped over the wall. John saw Mary with a telescope. Understands you like your mother. Copy the local patient files.

FORMULAS

Simplified Lesk Exam favourite

$$\text{sense}^* = \operatorname{argmax}_s |\text{context}(w) \cap \text{gloss}(s)|$$

Count the shared words between the sentence and each gloss, after removing very common words. Ties and zero overlaps fall back to the most frequent sense.

Lesson: Lexical ambiguity: one word, several meanings

Catalan numbers Exam favourite

$$C_n = \frac{1}{n+1} \times (2n \text{ choose } n) = \frac{(2n)!}{(n+1)!\, n!}$$

With k phrases the count is C_{k+1}: 2, 5, 14, 42, 132 for $k = 1$ to 5.

Lesson: Structural ambiguity: one string, several trees

Lexical association for attachment

$$\text{P(verb attachment)} \approx \frac{c(\text{verb, prep})}{c(\text{verb, prep}) + c(\text{noun, prep})}$$

In the spirit of Hindle and Rooth (1993): compare how strongly the preposition goes with the verb and with the noun in a large corpus.

Lesson: How machines resolve ambiguity

TABLES

Table: term · what it means · example

Term	What it means	Example
Homonymy	Same spelling and sound, unrelated meanings with different histories	bank (river, from Old Norse banki) and bank (money, from Italian banca, a bench)
Polysemy	One word, several related senses from one origin	mouth of a person and mouth of a river, head of a company
Homophone	Same sound, different spelling and meaning	pear and peer, write and right
Homograph	Same spelling, different sound and meaning	lead the metal and lead the verb

Lesson: Lexical ambiguity: one word, several meanings

Table: reading · where the phrase attaches · meaning

Reading	Where the phrase attaches	Meaning
Instrument	To the verb phrase (high attachment)	John used a telescope to see Mary
Possession	To the noun phrase Mary (low attachment)	John saw Mary, who had a telescope

Lesson: Structural ambiguity: one string, several trees

Table: era · approach · how it decides

Era	Approach	How it decides
1960s to 1980s	Rules and heuristics	Hand written grammar plus defaults such as right association (attach low, to the nearest phrase)
1990s to 2000s	Statistics from treebanks	Count how often a verb or noun takes this preposition in a hand parsed corpus, choose the more likely tree
2010s onward	Contextual neural models	Each word vector depends on the whole sentence, so telescope near astronomy and telescope near ship get different representations

Lesson: How machines resolve ambiguity

TIPS AND TRAPS

IN THE EXAM

If an exam asks you to classify an example, ask one question: does any single word have two meanings? If yes, lexical. If every word is clear but the grouping can change, structural.

Lesson: Structural ambiguity: one string, several trees

1.3 Can machines understand language?

Marr's levels, Turing and Total Turing tests, ELIZA against SHRDLU, how NLU systems are built and scored, and the debate on form and meaning.

KEY IDEAS

- **Marr** Computational (what and why), algorithmic (how, representation), implementational (where). Design top down, validate bottom up.
- **Turing test** Operational, text only, not reproducible. Qualia are outside it. The Total Turing Test adds perception and action, seven capabilities.
- **ELIZA and SHRDLU** ELIZA: keyword patterns, no understanding. SHRDLU: world model, reasoning, action and clarifying questions in a blocks world.
- **Fields and pipeline** NLP builds tools, CL models cognition, NLU is the shared goal. Corpus and annotation, model, then validation.
- **Metrics** $P = TP \div (TP + FP)$, $R = TP \div (TP + FN)$, $F1 = 2PR \div (P + R)$. $BLEU = BP \cdot \exp(\Sigma\ w \log p)$. Surprisal $-\log_2 P$. Dependency length.

- **Form against meaning** Firth and Shannon support data. The octopus test, Ettinger, symbol grounding and the Chinese room warn that form is not meaning.

FORMULAS

Precision, recall, F1

Exam favourite

$$P = \frac{TP}{TP + FP}, R = \frac{TP}{TP + FN}, F1 = \frac{2PR}{P + R}$$

Precision: how much of what you found is right. Recall: how much of the truth you found.

Lesson: NLP, CL and NLU, and how systems are measured

BLEU

Exam favourite

$$BLEU = BP \cdot \exp(\Sigma_n w_n \log p_n)$$

p_n is clipped n-gram precision, BP = 1 if $c > r$, else $e^{1 - r/c}$. Papineni et al. 2002.

Lesson: NLP, CL and NLU, and how systems are measured

Surprisal

$$S(w) = -\log_2 P(w \mid \text{context})$$

Surprising words take longer to read (Hale 2001, Levy 2008).

Lesson: NLP, CL and NLU, and how systems are measured

Dependency length

$$DL = \Sigma_i |i - \text{head}(i)|$$

Human sentences keep related words close (Gibson 2000).

Lesson: NLP, CL and NLU, and how systems are measured

TABLES

Table: level (marr, 1982) · question · what it specifies

Level (Marr, 1982)	Question	What it specifies
1. Computational	What and why?	The goal of the computation and why it is the right goal
2. Algorithmic or representational	How?	The representation of input and output, and the algorithm that turns one into the other
3. Implementational	Where?	The physical substrate: neurons, gears, silicon

Lesson: Marr's three levels and the robot that flies

Table: · like humans · rationally

	Like humans	Rationally
Thinking	Systems that think like humans (Haugeland, Bellman)	Systems that think rationally (Charniak and McDermott, Winston)
Acting	Systems that act like humans (Kurzweil, Rich and Knight)	Systems that act rationally (Schalkoff, Luger and Stubblefield)

Lesson: The Turing test and what it misses

Table: capability · why

Capability	Why
Natural language processing	Talk with the examiner
Knowledge representation	Store what it is told
Automated reasoning	Answer questions and draw conclusions
Machine learning	Adapt and find patterns
Vision	Recognise the examiner's actions and objects
Motor control	Act on objects when asked
Other senses	Hearing, touch, smell

Lesson: The Turing test and what it misses

Table: · eliza (1966) · shrdlu (about 1970)

	ELIZA (1966)	SHRDLU (about 1970)
Creator	Joseph Weizenbaum, MIT	Terry Winograd, MIT
Pipeline	Language → pattern match → response	Language → world model → reasoning → action → response
Grounding	None, text in and text out	In a simulated micro world
Domain	General chat	Blocks world only
Lesson	Fluent is not understanding	Language can be procedure tied to knowledge and action, at small scale

Lesson: ELIZA and SHRDLU: talking against understanding

Table: field · orientation · goal

Field	Orientation	Goal
NLP	Engineering, application driven	Build tools: search, speech to text, translation, sentiment
Computational linguistics	Science, theory driven	Model the human cognitive system for language
NLU	The shared end goal	A system that really understands, built from description to representation to evaluation

Lesson: NLP, CL and NLU, and how systems are measured

TIPS AND TRAPS

COMMON MISTAKE The professor calls jumping straight to hardware and algorithms "the rush that all computer engineers make". A purely data driven language model is tuned at levels 2 and 3 without a clear level 1 answer to what understanding is.

Lesson: Marr's three levels and the robot that flies

REMEMBER SHRDLU's "OK" matters because it reports that a grounded action was carried out, closing the loop between language and behaviour.

Lesson: ELIZA and SHRDLU: talking against understanding

STEP 2 Text as data

2.1 Sentences, tokens and vocabularies

The preprocessing pipeline, tokens and types, Punkt sentence splitting, Treebank word tokens, vocabularies and BPE subwords.

KEY IDEAS

- **Pipeline** Sentence segmentation, tokenisation, stemming or lemmatisation, POS tagging, counting.
- **Tokens and types** Token = an occurrence, type = a distinct word. N() and B() in FreqDist. TTR = V ÷ N falls as text grows.
- **Punkt** Unsupervised sentence splitter that learned abbreviations. Kept "Dr. jack" together: 3 sentences in the notebook.
- **Treebank tokens** Punctuation split off, Don't → Do n't, It's → It 's. 32 tokens for the notebook paragraph against 26 from split().
- **Subwords** BPE merges the most frequent adjacent pair again and again, so no word is out of vocabulary.

FORMULAS

Tokens and types Exam favourite

$$N = \text{number of tokens}, \quad V = |\text{vocabulary}| = \text{number of types}$$

FreqDist calls these N() (outcomes) and B() (samples).

Lesson: The preprocessing pipeline

Type token ratio

$$\text{TTR} = \frac{V}{N}$$

Higher means more varied vocabulary. It falls as a text gets longer, so only compare texts of similar length.

Lesson: The preprocessing pipeline

TABLES

Table: step · what it does · example

Step	What it does	Example
Sentence segmentation	Split a paragraph into sentences	"I came. I saw." → ["I came.", "I saw."]
Tokenisation	Split each sentence into tokens (words and punctuation)	"John went to Patna." → John, went, to, Patna, .
Stemming	Chop endings with rules. The stem need not be a word	gaming → game, leaves → leav
Lemmatisation	Map to the dictionary form using the part of speech	children → child, leaves → leaf
POS tagging	Give each token a grammatical category	John/NNP went/VBD to/TO Patna/NNP
Frequency distribution	Count tokens or tags	FreqDist(brown.words()).most_common(10)

Lesson: The preprocessing pipeline

Table: convention · example · why

Convention	Example	Why
Punctuation is its own token	boy. → boy, .	So "boy" and "boy." are one type
Contractions split off	Don't → Do, n't It's → It, 's	n't is the word not, 's can be is or a possessive
Abbreviations stay whole	Dr. stays Dr.	The full stop is part of the word
Only the sentence final stop is split	Jodhpur. → Jodhpur, .	Inner stops belong to abbreviations or numbers

Lesson: Word tokenisation

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER — Full stops are ambiguous in English: end of sentence, abbreviation, decimal point, or part of an email address. Segmentation is a classification problem for every full stop.

Lesson: Sentence segmentation

IN THE EXAM — Every SRILM file in chapter 6 has one sentence per line with tokens separated by spaces. That format is the result of exactly the segmentation and tokenisation in this chapter.

Lesson: Reading text files in Python

2.2 Stems and lemmas

Inflection and derivation, Porter stemming and the measure m, Snowball and Lancaster, WordNet lemmatisation, stem against lemma, and the precision and recall trade off.

KEY IDEAS

- **Stem against lemma** Stem: rule based chop, may not be a word (leaves → leav). Lemma: dictionary form, uses POS (leaves → leaf, children → child).
- **Porter measure** Word = [C](VC)^m[V]. tree 0, trouble 1, troubles 2. y after a consonant is a vowel.

- **Notebook results** Porter: sportingli, fairli, boy'. Snowball: sport, fair, boy. Exercise list differs only on alumnus.
- **Lemmatiser needs POS** WordNetLemmatizer defaults to noun. loving stays loving, but with pos='v' it becomes love.
- **Errors and effect** Over stemming: university, universe → univers. Under stemming: alumnus and alumni stay apart. Stemming raises recall, may lower precision.

FORMULAS

Vocabulary after normalisation

$$V_{\text{after}} \le V_{\text{before}}, \quad \text{reduction} = 1 - \frac{V_{\text{after}}}{V_{\text{before}}}$$

Merging forms can only lower the number of types. Above, 5 types become 1, a reduction of 80 percent.

Lesson: Words have parts

Why counts improve

$$c(\text{connect*}) = c(\text{connect}) + c(\text{connected}) + c(\text{connecting}) + \dots$$

Evidence that was split over five rare types is pooled into one common type. Chapter 4 shows why fewer, larger counts give better probabilities.

Lesson: Words have parts

Porter's word shape

Exam favourite

$$[C]\,(VC)^m\,[V]$$

Square brackets mean optional. m counts how many times a vowel run is followed by a consonant run.

Lesson: Stemming: chop with rules

Examples from Porter (1980)

$$m = 0\text{: tree, by}$$
$$m = 1\text{: trouble, oats, ivy}$$
$$m = 2\text{: troubles, private}$$

tr-ee is C V, so m = 0. tr-ou-bl-e is C V C V, so m = 1.

Lesson: Stemming: chop with rules

Precision and recall

Exam favourite

$$P = \frac{\text{relevant returned}}{\text{all returned}} \qquad R = \frac{\text{relevant returned}}{\text{all relevant}}$$

Both lie between 0 and 1.

Lesson: Stem or lemma: choosing well

F1 score

$$F_1 = \frac{2\,P\,R}{P + R}$$

The harmonic mean. It is high only when both P and R are high.

Lesson: Stem or lemma: choosing well

TABLES

Table: word · morphemes · count

Word	Morphemes	Count
rebuilding	re- (bound prefix, again) + build (free root) + -ing (bound suffix, progressive)	3
unhelpful	un- (bound prefix, not) + help (free root) + -ful (bound suffix, full of)	3
teachers	teach (free root) + -er (bound suffix, one who) + -s (bound suffix, plural)	3
impossibility	im- (bound prefix, not) + possible (free root) + -ity (bound suffix, makes a noun)	3

Lesson: Words have parts

Table: · inflection · derivation

	Inflection	Derivation
What it does	Adds grammar: number, tense, person, comparison	Makes a new word, often a new part of speech
Examples	cat → cats, walk → walked, big → bigger	teach → teacher, happy → happiness, nation → national
Part of speech	Stays the same	Often changes (verb → noun)
Lemma	Same lemma as the base word	A different lemma with its own dictionary entry

Lesson: Words have parts

Table: step · job · example rules · examples

Step	Job	Example rules	Examples
1a	Plurals	SSES → SS, IES → I, SS → SS, S → nothing	caresses → caress, ponies → poni, cats → cat
1b	Past tense and -ing	(m > 0) EED → EE, (*v*) ED → nothing, (*v*) ING → nothing, then tidy up	plastered → plaster, motoring → motor, hopping → hop, sing → sing
1c	Final y	(*v*) Y → I	happy → happi, sky → sky
2	Double suffixes	(m > 0) ATIONAL → ATE, IZATION → IZE, FULNESS → FUL	relational → relate, vietnamization → vietnamize
3	More endings	(m > 0) ICATE → IC, FUL → nothing, NESS → nothing	triplicate → triplic, hopeful → hope, goodness → good
4	Long suffixes	(m > 1) AL, ANCE, ENCE, ER, IC, ABLE, IBLE, ANT, EMENT, MENT, ENT, ION, ISM, ATE, IVE ... → nothing	revival → reviv, adjustable → adjust, adoption → adopt
5	Tidy the end	(m > 1) E → nothing, (m > 1 and double L) → single L	probate → probat, rate → rate, controll → control

Lesson: Inside the Porter algorithm

Table: word · porter · snowball · lancaster

Word	Porter	Snowball	Lancaster
sportingly	sportingli	sport	sport
fairly	fairli	fair	fair
gaming	game	game	gam
generously	gener	generous	gen
organization	organ	organ	org
studies	studi	studi	study
maximum	maximum	maximum	maxim

Lesson: Inside the Porter algorithm

Table: · stem · lemma

	Stem	Lemma
Definition	What is left after rule based suffix stripping	The dictionary (citation) form of the word
Real word	Not always: leaves → leav, studies → studi	Always: leaves → leaf, studies → study
Needs	Only a rule list	A dictionary and the part of speech
Irregular forms	Missed: children, saw, better unchanged	Handled: child, see (verb), good (adjective)
Speed	Very fast	Slower (tagging plus lookup)
Typical use	Search engines, quick text classification	Question answering, chatbots, linguistics

Lesson: Stem or lemma: choosing well

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER

Hindi, Turkish, Finnish and Tamil pack many more endings into one word than English does. One Turkish verb can have hundreds of forms, so normalisation matters even more for them.

Lesson: Words have parts

IN THE EXAM

In an exam, write the C and V pattern under the letters first, then count VC pairs. Most mistakes come from forgetting that y after a consonant is a vowel.

Lesson: Stemming: chop with rules

COMMON MISTAKE Run a POS tagger first and pass each tag to the lemmatiser. Without the tag, most verbs and adjectives come back unchanged, exactly as in the notebook output above.

Lesson: Lemmatisation: look it up

2.3 Counting words and tags

FreqDist, the Brown corpus and the Penn Treebank with real counts, tagsets and tag mapping, and the first bigram probabilities.

KEY IDEAS

- **FreqDist** N() = tokens (outcomes), B() = types (samples), freq(x) = c(x)/N, unseen count = 0. a b a a c b a gives 3 samples, 7 outcomes, freq(a) = 0.5714.
- **Brown numbers** 1,161,192 tokens, 56,057 types, the = 62,713 (5.40%). 472 distinct tags, top tag NN 152,470.
- **PTB numbers** 100,676 tokens, 12,408 types, comma is most common (4,885), the 4,045 (4.02%). 6,592 -NONE- tokens.
- **Tagsets** 8 traditional, 12 universal, 17 UPOS, 45 PTB, about 87 Brown. Fine maps to coarse: ADV 3,171 = RB + RBR + RBS + WRB.
- **Bigram counts** P(w | prev) = c(prev w) / c(prev). From I am Sam: P(am | I) = 2/3.

FORMULAS

Relative frequency Exam favourite

$$\text{freq}(x) = \frac{c(x)}{N}$$

This is also the maximum likelihood estimate of P(x). Chapter 4 builds language models from exactly this ratio.

Lesson: Counting with FreqDist

Check

$$\sum_x \text{freq}(x) = 1$$

The relative frequencies of all samples always add to one, so they form a probability distribution.

Lesson: Counting with FreqDist

Merging tags adds their counts Exam favourite

$$c(\text{ADV}) = c(\text{RB}) + c(\text{RBR}) + c(\text{RBS}) + c(\text{WRB})$$

Every universal tag count is the sum of the PTB tags mapped to it.

Lesson: How many tags? Tagsets

Notebook numbers

$$3{,}171 = 2{,}822 + 136 + 35 + 178$$

RB does not exist in the universal tagset, so fdist["RB"] gave 0 there.

Lesson: How many tags? Tagsets

Bigram probability by counting Exam favourite

$$P(w_i \mid w_{i-1}) = \frac{c(w_{i-1}\, w_i)}{c(w_{i-1})}$$

The maximum likelihood estimate. Chapter 4 explains why it fails for pairs never seen.

Lesson: Counting pairs: towards language models

Most frequent tag baseline

$$\text{tag}(w) = \text{argmax}_t\, c(w, t)$$

Counting word and tag pairs gives the simplest tagger. Chapter 5 adds context.

Lesson: Counting pairs: towards language models

TABLES

Table: call · meaning · value here

Call	Meaning	Value here
fdist[x]	Count of x. An unseen item gives 0, not an error	fdist['a'] = 4, fdist['d'] = 0
N()	Number of outcomes, which is every token counted	7
B()	Number of samples (bins), which is the distinct types	3
freq(x)	Relative frequency, count of x divided by N	4 ÷ 7 = 0.5714
max()	The most common sample	a
most_common(k)	The k most common samples with counts	[('a', 4), ('b', 2)] for k = 2

Lesson: Counting with FreqDist

Table: · brown corpus · penn treebank (nltk sample)

	Brown corpus	Penn Treebank (NLTK sample)
Source	500 samples of American English printed in 1961, from 15 genres such as news, fiction and science	Wall Street Journal news articles
Built by	Francis and Kučera at Brown University	Marcus, Santorini and Marcinkiewicz at the University of Pennsylvania (1993)
Tokens in NLTK	1,161,192	100,676
Types	56,057	12,408
Most common word	the (62,713 times, 5.40%)	, (4,885 times). the is second with 4,045 (4.02%)
Distinct tags	472 (compound tags counted separately)	46 PTB tags, or 12 universal tags

Lesson: Corpora: Brown and the Penn Treebank

Table: tagset · size · example distinctions

Tagset	Size	Example distinctions
Traditional grammar	8	noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection
Universal (Petrov et al., 2012)	12	NOUN VERB ADJ ADV PRON DET ADP NUM CONJ PRT . X
Universal Dependencies UPOS	17	adds PROPN, AUX, SCONJ, SYM, INTJ, PUNCT
Penn Treebank	45	NN NNS NNP NNPS, VB VBD VBG VBN VBP VBZ, JJ JJR JJS, RB RBR RBS
Brown	about 87 base tags	plus compound forms such as NN-TL and NP$, which is why NLTK counts 472

Lesson: How many tags? Tagsets

Table: fine tagset (ptb, brown) · coarse tagset (universal)

Fine tagset (PTB, Brown)	Coarse tagset (universal)
More information: singular or plural, past or present	Less information
Harder to tag, because there are more classes to confuse	Easier and more accurate
Useful for parsing and grammar checking	Useful across languages, since the same 12 tags fit most languages

Lesson: How many tags? Tagsets

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER An item seen once is called a hapax legomenon (Greek for "said once"). In real corpora about half of all types are hapaxes. They are the reason smoothing exists, which is the subject of chapter 4.

Lesson: Counting with FreqDist

IN THE EXAM Exam questions often ask you to "verbally describe how the results differ". Mention size, genre, tagset and the -NONE- tokens, and back each point with one number.

Lesson: Corpora: Brown and the Penn Treebank

STEP 3 Information and surprise

3.1 Zipf's law and the shape of vocabulary

Zipf's law f = k/r, the Brown check, coverage by harmonic numbers, least effort, Mandelbrot and Heaps, and why random typing is also Zipfian.

KEY IDEAS

- **Zipf's law** f = k/r, f × r ≈ constant, slope −1 on log log axes. f_a/f_b = b/a, so the 50th word is 3 times the 150th.
- **Brown check** the 69,971, of 36,412 (ratio 1.92). f × r stays between about 70,000 and 107,000. Real slope about −1.08.
- **Coverage** Top n share = H_n/H_V, H_n ≈ ln n + 0.5772. V = 50,000: top 10 = 25.7%, top 100 = 45.5%.
- **Least effort** Frequent words are short (law of abbreviation). Language balances speaker effort and listener robustness.
- **Monkey typing** Random keys give a power law with α = 1 − ln(1 − s)/ln M (1.0116 for 27 keys) but no predictability.

FORMULAS

Three dice

$$P(\text{sum} = 3) = \frac{1}{216} \approx 0.005, \quad P(\text{sum} = 10) = \frac{27}{216} = 0.125$$

Counts for sums 3 to 18: 1, 3, 6, 10, 15, 21, 25, 27, 27, 25, 21, 15, 10, 6, 3, 1.

Lesson: Do words have an average frequency?

Words

$$c(\text{the}) = 69{,}971, \quad \text{types seen once} = 16{,}540$$

Brown corpus, lower cased. One word fills about 7% of the text while thousands of words appear once. There is no typical value.

Lesson: Do words have an average frequency?

Zipf's law Exam favourite

$$f = \frac{k}{r} \quad \text{or} \quad f \times r \approx k$$

f is the frequency of the word of rank r and k is a constant for the corpus. The frequency falls as one over the rank.

Lesson: Zipf's law

Ratio rule Exam favourite

$$\frac{f_a}{f_b} = \frac{b}{a}$$

The top word is about twice the second, three times the third. The 50th word is three times the 150th.

Lesson: Zipf's law

Share of the top n words

Exam favourite

$$\text{share}(n) = \frac{H_n}{H_V}, \quad H_n = 1 + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{3} + \ldots + \frac{1}{n}$$

V is the vocabulary size. Total tokens are k H_V and the top n words have k H_n of them.

Lesson: How much text do the top words cover?

Approximation

$$H_n \approx \ln n + \gamma, \quad \gamma \approx 0.5772$$

γ is the Euler Mascheroni constant. The sum of 1/r grows like the area under 1/x.

Lesson: How much text do the top words cover?

Random typing exponent

Exam favourite

$$\alpha = 1 - \frac{\ln(1 - s)}{\ln M}$$

M letters, space probability s. As M grows α tends to 1 for any fixed s.

Lesson: The Zipf mystery: monkey typing

TABLES

Table: function words · content words

Function words	Content words
the, of, and, to, a, in, that	nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs
Short and extremely frequent	Longer and rarer
A closed class: new ones almost never appear	An open class: new words appear all the time
Glue that joins the content words	Carry the meaning and the topic
Little information each, since they are predictable	Much information each, since they are surprising

Lesson: Do words have an average frequency?

Table: rank r · word · frequency f · f × r

Rank r	Word	Frequency f	f × r
1	the	69,971	69,971
2	of	36,412	72,824
3	and	28,853	86,559
10	he	9,548	95,480
50	no	2,139	106,950
150	three	610	91,500
1,000	eight	104	104,000
10,000	incredibly	7	70,000

Lesson: Zipf's law

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER

Why no bell curve? A normal curve appears when a value is the sum of many small independent effects. Word frequency is not a sum. It comes from people choosing words, and a few grammatical words are chosen in almost every sentence.

Lesson: Do words have an average frequency?

IN THE EXAM

The class question "should the 50th word occur three times as often as the 150th?" has answer yes: $f_{50} \div f_{150} = 150 \div 50 = 3$. On Brown the real ratio is 2,139 ÷ 610 = 3.51, a little steeper, as the slope of −1.08 suggests.

Lesson: Zipf's law

3.2 Surprise, entropy and redundancy

Surprisal, entropy and its bounds, Huffman codes and the source coding limit, Shannon's approximations, context and the 50% redundancy of English.

KEY IDEAS

- **Surprisal** I(x) = $-\log_2 p(x)$. p = 1 gives 0 bits, each halving adds 1 bit. Bits, nats, hartleys.
- **Entropy** H = $-\Sigma\ p \log_2 p$ = expected surprise. $0 \le H \le \log_2 n$. Coin 1 bit, 8 sided die 3 bits, certain event 0.
- **Codes** Fixed length needs $\lceil \log_2 n \rceil$ bits. Huffman merges the two least likely. $H \le \bar{L} < H + 1$. Example 1.9 against H 1.846.
- **Redundancy** R = 1 − H/H_max. English about 2.3 of 4.7 bits per letter, so about 50% redundant. u after q carries 0.02 bits.
- **Limits of H** Single symbol entropy ignores order (ABAB has 1 bit). Language needs conditional entropy: context reduces uncertainty.

FORMULAS

Surprisal of one outcome — Exam favourite

$$I(x) = -\log_2 p(x) = \log_2 \frac{1}{p(x)}$$

Measured in bits. A certain event (p = 1) gives 0 bits. Every halving of the probability adds exactly 1 bit.

Lesson: Information is surprise

Units

$$\log_2 \rightarrow \text{bits}, \quad \ln \rightarrow \text{nats}, \quad \log_{10} \rightarrow \text{hartleys}$$

1 nat = 1.4427 bits and 1 hartley = 3.3219 bits. Changing the base only rescales.

Lesson: Information is surprise

Shannon's entropy — Exam favourite

$$H(X) = -\sum_x p(x) \log_2 p(x) = \mathrm{E}[\ -\log_2 p(X)\ ]$$

The average uncertainty, the expected surprise, and the fewest bits per outcome any code can use on average. 0 log 0 is taken as 0.

Lesson: Entropy: average surprise

Bounds — Exam favourite

$$0 \le H(X) \le \log_2 n$$

H = 0 only when one outcome is certain. H = $\log_2$ n only when all n outcomes are equally likely.

Lesson: Entropy: average surprise

Fixed length code

$$\text{bits} = \lceil \log_2 n \rceil$$

20 amino acids need 5 bits, 100 words need 7, 50,000 words need 16.

Lesson: Entropy as the shortest code

Source coding theorem — Exam favourite

$$H(X) \le \bar{L} < H(X) + 1$$

No lossless code can average fewer than H bits per symbol. The best symbol by symbol code, Huffman, is within 1 bit.

Lesson: Entropy as the shortest code

Redundancy — Exam favourite

$$R = 1 - \frac{H}{H_{\max}}$$

R = 0 for random text. R near 1 means most of the text could be predicted and removed.

Lesson: Context and redundancy

Shannon's estimate for English

$$R = 1 - \frac{2.3}{\log_2 26} = 1 - \frac{2.3}{4.70} \approx 51\%$$

With about 8 letters of context each character carries about 2.3 bits, not 5. English is roughly half redundant.

Lesson: Context and redundancy

TABLES

Table: source · probabilities · entropy

Source	Probabilities	Entropy
Fair coin	½, ½	1 bit
Coin with P(heads) = 0.9	0.9, 0.1	0.469 bits
Coin with P(heads) = 0.99	0.99, 0.01	0.081 bits
Fair 8 sided die	⅛ each	3 bits
Fair 6 sided die	⅙ each	2.585 bits
Loaded die	P(6) = 0.5, others 0.1	2.161 bits
Certain event	1, 0	0 bits

Lesson: Entropy: average surprise

Table: order · constraint · shannon's sample

Order	Constraint	Shannon's sample
0	All 27 symbols equally likely	XFOML RXKHRJFFJUJ ZLPWCFWKCYJ
1	English letter frequencies	OCRO HLI RGWR NIMILWIS EU LL
2	Letter pairs match English	ON IE ANTSOUTINYS ARE T INCTORE ST
3	Letter triples match English	IN NO IST LAT WHEY CRATICT FROURE
Words, 2	Word pairs match English	THE HEAD AND IN FRONTAL ATTACK ON AN ENGLISH WRITER

Lesson: Context and redundancy

Table: context so far · class guesses · choices

Context so far	Class guesses	Choices
A ___	any noun	huge
A SMALL ___	bus, book, kitchen, kid	drastically fewer
A SMALL OBLONG ___	table, desk, board	a surprising word raises uncertainty for a moment
... OBLONG READING ___	lamp	almost certain
... LAMP ON THE D___	desk	one letter removes almost all doubt

Lesson: Context and redundancy

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER — Because these measures are logarithms, independent pieces of evidence simply add. That is the reason Turing, Hartley and Shannon all used logs.

Lesson: Information is surprise

REMEMBER — Ths sntnc s stll rdbl. Removing the vowels deletes about 38% of the letters but almost none of the information, because vowels are predictable from the consonants. That is redundancy you can see.

Lesson: Context and redundancy

3.3 Mutual information, KL and the noisy channel

Joint and conditional entropy, the chain rule, mutual information and PMI, KL divergence and cross entropy, and noisy channel decoding.

KEY IDEAS

- **Joint and conditional** $H(Y|X) = \Sigma\, p(x)\, H(Y|X=x) = -\Sigma\, p(x,y) \log p(y|x)$. Chain rule $H(X,Y) = H(X) + H(Y|X)$. Umbrella: 0.971 + 0.621 = 1.592.

- **Mutual information** $I = H(Y) - H(Y|X) = H(X) + H(Y) - H(X,Y) = \Sigma\ p(x,y) \log p(x,y)/(p(x)p(y))$. Symmetric, ≥ 0, 0 iff independent. Umbrella 0.378.
- **PMI** $\log_2 c(xy)N/(c(x)c(y))$. New Delhi 8.64, new car 3.32. Collocations score highest. Rare pairs are over rewarded.
- **KL and cross entropy** $D(p\|q) = \Sigma\ p \log p/q \geq 0$, not symmetric, infinite if $q = 0$ where $p > 0$. $H(p,q) = H(p) + D(p\|q)$.
- **Noisy channel** $\text{argmax}\ p(i)\ p(o|i)$: language model times channel model. acress → actress (0.485). BSC 10%: $C = 0.531$.

FORMULAS

Joint entropy

$$H(X, Y) = -\sum_{x,y} p(x, y) \log_2 p(x, y)$$

The information needed on average to specify both values, like "New" and "Delhi" together.

Lesson: Joint and conditional entropy

Conditional entropy

Exam favourite

$$H(Y \mid X) = \sum_x p(x)\, H(Y \mid X = x) = -\sum_{x,y} p(x, y) \log_2 p(y \mid x)$$

The extra information still needed for Y once X is known. The joint probability goes outside the log, the conditional inside.

Lesson: Joint and conditional entropy

Chain rule

Exam favourite

$$H(X, Y) = H(X) + H(Y \mid X)$$

Specify X, then specify Y given X. For n variables: $H(X_1 \ldots X_n) = \Sigma\ H(X_i \mid X_1 \ldots X_{i-1})$.

Lesson: Joint and conditional entropy

Mutual information

Exam favourite

$$I(X : Y) = H(Y) - H(Y \mid X) = H(X) + H(Y) - H(X, Y)$$

The overlap of the two entropy circles, in bits. Many textbooks put a semicolon between X and Y in this notation.

Lesson: Mutual information

Probability form

$$I(X : Y) = \sum_{x,y} p(x, y) \log_2 \frac{p(x, y)}{p(x)\, p(y)}$$

Zero exactly when $p(x, y) = p(x)\, p(y)$ for every pair, which is independence.

Lesson: Mutual information

Pointwise mutual information

Exam favourite

$$\text{PMI}(x, y) = \log_2 \frac{p(x, y)}{p(x)\, p(y)} = \log_2 \frac{c(x\, y) \cdot N}{c(x) \cdot c(y)}$$

Above 0 the words attract, 0 means independent, below 0 they avoid each other. MI is the average of PMI over all pairs.

Lesson: Mutual information

Kullback Leibler divergence

Exam favourite

$$D(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_x p(x) \log_2 \frac{p(x)}{q(x)}$$

The average number of bits wasted by coding data from p with a code built for q.

Lesson: KL divergence and cross entropy

Cross entropy

Exam favourite

$$H(p, q) = -\sum_x p(x) \log_2 q(x) = H(p) + D(p \,\|\, q)$$

Training a language model with cross entropy loss lowers the KL from the truth to the model, since H(p) is fixed by the data.

Lesson: KL divergence and cross entropy

Noisy channel decoding

Exam favourite

$$\hat{\imath} = \text{argmax}_i\, p(i \mid o) = \text{argmax}_i\, p(i) \cdot p(o \mid i)$$

p(i) is the language model (how likely is this input). p(o | i) is the channel model (how likely is this output from it). Used for spelling correction, speech recognition, OCR and translation.

Lesson: The noisy channel

Channel capacity

$$C = \max_{p(X)} I(X : Y)$$

A binary channel that flips 10% of bits has $C = 1 - H(0.1) = 0.531$ bits per use.

Lesson: The noisy channel

TABLES

Table: · collocation · association

	Collocation	Association
Examples	New Delhi, fast food, strong tea, make a decision	new car, doctor and nurse
Can a word be swapped?	No: quick food and powerful tea sound wrong	Yes: new bike, new dress
Meaning	Often not built from the parts	Built from the parts
PMI	Highest	Positive but lower

Lesson: Mutual information

Table: example · d(p ‖ q) · d(q ‖ p)

Example	D(p ‖ q)	D(q ‖ p)
p = (0.5, 0.25, 0.25), q uniform	0.0850 bits	0.0817 bits
City A weather (0.7, 0.2, 0.1) against city B (0.3, 0.3, 0.4)	0.539 bits	0.609 bits
p = (0.5, 0.5, 0), q = (0.4, 0.4, 0.2)	0.322 bits	∞

Lesson: KL divergence and cross entropy

TIPS AND TRAPS

COMMON MISTAKE A student guessed $-\Sigma\, p(x,y) \log p(x|y)$. That is not H(Y|X), but it is a correct formula for H(X|Y): the conditioning just runs the other way. In the umbrella example it gives 0.593 bits against 0.621 for H(Y|X).

Lesson: Joint and conditional entropy

COMMON MISTAKE PMI over rewards rare pairs. Two words seen once, together, score $\log_2 N$, more than New Delhi. Always use a minimum count, or a t-score or log likelihood ratio, alongside it.

Lesson: Mutual information

IN THE EXAM If a model gives probability 0 to something that happens, KL and perplexity become infinite. That single fact is why every n-gram model in chapter 4 is smoothed, and why neural models use a softmax, which never outputs exactly 0.

Lesson: KL divergence and cross entropy

STEP 4 Language models

4.1 N-gram models and the Markov assumption

The chain rule, the Markov assumption, MLE counting, the start and end tags, and the bigram and unigram activity.

KEY IDEAS

- **Markov assumption** An n-gram looks at n − 1 previous words. Bigram = first order Markov chain. Chain rule is exact, the n-gram is an approximation.
- **MLE** P(w | h) = C(h w) ÷ C(h). Unigram P(w) = C(w) ÷ N. Proof: Lagrange multiplier gives the relative frequency.
- **The tags** <s> is context only, </s> is predicted. Activity corpus: N = 17 + 5 = 22, six predicted types.
- **Activity answers** Bigram S1 = 6/625 = 0.0096 (log −2.01773, PP 2.169), S2 = 0.072. Unigram S1 = 3.3075e-5, S2 = 1.0672e-3.
- **Perplexity N** Use the tokens of the sentence being scored: words + </s> for PP, words for PP1. Never the training N.

FORMULAS

Conditional estimate

Exam favourite

$$\text{m}(\text{jelly} \mid \text{peanut butter and}) = \frac{\text{C}(\text{peanut butter and jelly})}{\text{C}(\text{peanut butter and})}$$

Count the whole four word sequence, then divide by how often the three word history occurred.

Lesson: Why predict the next word?

Chain rule (exact)

Exam favourite

$$\text{P}(w_1 \ldots w_n) = \text{P}(w_1) \cdot \text{P}(w_2 \mid w_1) \cdot \text{P}(w_3 \mid w_1\, w_2) \cdots \text{P}(w_n \mid w_1 \ldots w_{n-1})$$

No approximation yet. Every word is conditioned on everything before it.

Lesson: Why predict the next word?

Markov assumption

Exam favourite

$$\text{P}(w_i \mid w_1 \ldots w_{i-1}) \approx \text{P}(w_i \mid w_{i-n+1} \ldots w_{i-1})$$

The next word depends only on the last n – 1 words. An n-gram has n words: n – 1 of context and one predicted.

Lesson: The Markov assumption

Bigram model

$$\text{P}(w_1 \ldots w_n) \approx \prod_i \text{P}(w_i \mid w_{i-1})$$

A bigram model is a first order Markov chain over words. A trigram model is second order.

Lesson: The Markov assumption

Bigram MLE

Exam favourite

$$\text{P}(w_n \mid w_{n-1}) = \frac{\text{C}(w_{n-1}\, w_n)}{\text{C}(w_{n-1})}$$

Because every occurrence of a word is followed by exactly one token, possibly </s>, the bigram counts in a row add up to the count of the history.

Lesson: Counting: the maximum likelihood estimate

General n-gram MLE

$$\text{P}(w_n \mid w_{n-N+1} \ldots w_{n-1}) = \frac{\text{C}(w_{n-N+1} \ldots w_{n-1}\, w_n)}{\text{C}(w_{n-N+1} \ldots w_{n-1})}$$

Pad each sentence with n – 1 start tags so the first word also has a full history.

Lesson: Counting: the maximum likelihood estimate

Unigram MLE

$$\text{P}(w) = \frac{\text{C}(w)}{N}$$

N counts every token the model must predict: the words and one </s> per sentence, never <s>.

Lesson: Counting: the maximum likelihood estimate

TABLES

Table: model · n · context words · factor for "coffee" in "he put the coffee on the table"

Model	n	Context words	Factor for "coffee" in "He put the coffee on the table"
Unigram	1	0	P(coffee)
Bigram	2	1	P(coffee | the)
Trigram	3	2	P(coffee | put the)
4-gram	4	3	P(coffee | He put the)
5-gram	5	4	P(on | He put the coffee)

Lesson: The Markov assumption

Table: token · <s> · i · sam

Token	<s>	I	Sam	am	do	like	</s>	Words	Words and </s>
Count	5	5	5	2	2	3	5	17	22

Lesson: Counting: the maximum likelihood estimate

TIPS AND TRAPS

COMMON MISTAKE A student first answered "count jelly and divide by the total number of words". That is P(jelly), the unigram probability, which ignores the history. The question asks for the conditional probability, which needs the joint count of the whole sequence.

Lesson: Why predict the next word?

IN THE EXAM In class the answer to "how many context words does a 5-gram have?" came out garbled. The rule is simple: n words in total, the last is predicted, so a 5-gram has 4 context words.

Lesson: The Markov assumption

COMMON MISTAKE Three errors in the answer sheet are worth knowing. It labels unigram factors as P(Sam | <s>), but a unigram has no condition. Its product for S1 lists three numbers and gives 3.25×10^{-5}, which comes from rounding 5/22 to 0.227. The exact value is 3.3075×10^{-5}. And many students used N = 17 or 27, or conditioned the unigram on the previous word.

Lesson: The activity: which sentence is better?

IN THE EXAM PP divides the total surprise by words plus </s>, PP1 by words only, so PP1 is always the larger. The N in PP = $P^{-1/N}$ is the length of the sentence being scored, 6 for S1, not the 22 tokens of the training corpus. The professor saw that mistake in many submissions.

Lesson: The activity: which sentence is better?

4.2 Perplexity and evaluating language models

Perplexity from entropy, ppl and ppl1, file perplexity, underflow, the WSJ table and fair comparison.

KEY IDEAS

- **Perplexity** PP = $2^{\hat{H}} = P^{-1/N}$. Uniform over k words gives PP = k. "He put the coffee on": 13.288 bits, $\hat{H}$ 2.658, PP 6.31.
- **ppl and ppl1** Same logprob. ppl divides by words − OOV − zeroprobs + sentences, ppl1 by words − OOV − zeroprobs. File ppl from totals, not an average.
- **Evaluation** Extrinsic (task) against intrinsic (likelihood, log likelihood, perplexity). Use logs to avoid underflow below about 10^{-308}.
- **Rules** Never train or tune on the test set. Compare perplexities only with the same test text and vocabulary. Report OOVs.
- **WSJ** Unigram 962, bigram 170, trigram 109 (9.91, 7.41, 6.77 bits). Test perplexity is 2 to the cross entropy, which is at least the true entropy.

FORMULAS

Pointwise conditional entropy

$$-\log_2 \mathrm{m}(w_i \mid h_i)$$

The surprise of one word given its history.

Lesson: From surprise to perplexity

Total surprise

$$H_{\text{total}} = -\sum_i \log_2 \mathrm{m}(w_i \mid h_i) = -\log_2 \mathrm{m}(w_1 \ldots w_N)$$

Logs turn the chain rule product into a sum.

Lesson: From surprise to perplexity

Perplexity Exam favourite

$$\mathrm{PP} = 2^{\hat{H}}, \quad \hat{H} = \frac{H_{\text{total}}}{N}, \quad \text{so} \quad \mathrm{PP} = \mathrm{m}(w_1 \ldots w_N)^{-1/N}$$

Lower perplexity means the model found the text less surprising.

Lesson: From surprise to perplexity

ppl Exam favourite

$$\text{ppl} = 10^{-\text{logprob} \div (\text{words} - \text{OOVs} - \text{zeroprobs} + \text{sentences})}$$

Counts one </s> per sentence: how hard is it to predict every token, including where the sentence ends?

Lesson: PP, PP1 and whole files

ppl1 Exam favourite

$$\text{ppl1} = 10^{-\text{logprob} \div (\text{words} - \text{OOVs} - \text{zeroprobs})}$$

Words only. The cost of predicting the end is charged to the words, so ppl1 ≥ ppl always.

Lesson: PP, PP1 and whole files

The three intrinsic measures Exam favourite

$$\text{likelihood } \mathrm{m}(\text{test}), \quad \text{log likelihood } \log \mathrm{m}(\text{test}), \quad \text{PP} = \mathrm{m}(\text{test})^{-1/\mathrm{N}}$$

Higher likelihood, higher log likelihood and lower perplexity all mean the same thing, on the same test set and vocabulary.

Lesson: Evaluating language models

Test set cross entropy Exam favourite

$$\hat{H} = -\frac{1}{N} \log_2 \mathrm{m}(w_1 \ldots w_N) \approx H(p, \mathrm{m}) = H(p) + D(p \,\|\, \mathrm{m})$$

For long text this tends to the cross entropy of the truth p with the model m.

Lesson: Perplexity as cross entropy

TABLES

Table: · extrinsic · intrinsic

	Extrinsic	Intrinsic
What	Put the model inside an application and measure the application	Measure the model alone on held out text
Examples	The London word order task, translation, speech recognition, spelling correction	Likelihood, log likelihood, perplexity on a test set
Strength	Measures what we really care about	Cheap, fast and repeatable
Weakness	Slow and expensive	A lower perplexity usually, but not always, gives a better application

Lesson: Evaluating language models

Table: model · perplexity · bits per word

Model	Perplexity	Bits per word
Unigram	962	9.91
Bigram	170	7.41
Trigram	109	6.77

Lesson: Evaluating language models

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER Base 2 gives bits, base e gives nats, base 10 gives hartleys. Perplexity does not depend on the base as long as you raise the same base you took the log with: $2^{\hat{H} \text{ in bits}} = 10^{\hat{H} \text{ in hartleys}}$. That is why SRILM can print $\log_{10}$ values and still match the textbook.

Lesson: From surprise to perplexity

IN THE EXAM For long documents PP and PP1 converge, since there is one end tag per twenty or more words. For three word toy sentences they differ a lot (1.93 against 2.40). In an exam, say which N you used and never compare PP from one model with PP1 from another.

Lesson: PP, PP1 and whole files

REMEMBER Adding another source of information, such as tone of voice or a facial expression, can only lower conditional entropy on average: H(Y | X, Z) ≤ H(Y | X). Sarcasm is the classic case where the text misleads and the voice resolves it.

Lesson: Perplexity as cross entropy

4.3 Unseen words and smoothing

<UNK>, Laplace and add-k, discounting methods and Kneser-Ney, backoff, interpolation and λ tuning.

KEY IDEAS

- **Two zeros** OOV word: map to <UNK>. Unseen n-gram of known words: smooth, back off or interpolate. One zero factor gives P = 0 and PP = ∞.
- **Laplace and add-k** (C + k) ÷ (C(h) + kV). V = 7 for the activity. S3 Laplace bigram = 1/17010, PP 5.07. Sums to 1 by adding kV.
- **Discounting** Absolute: max(C − d, 0)/C(h) + λP(w), λ = d N_{1+}/C(h). Good-Turing: c* = (c+1)N_{c+1}/N_c, unseen N_1/N. KN uses continuation counts.
- **Backoff** Use the highest order with evidence, discounted, with α so the row sums to 1. Problem: "John eats blue", unseen is not always sparse.
- **Interpolation** Σλ P = 1 when Σλ = 1. Tune λ on dev (S3: best near 0.48, PP 6.43), report test once. EM for many λ.

FORMULAS

Laplace (add-one) Exam favourite

$$P_{\text{Lap}}(w) = \frac{C(w) + 1}{N + V}, \quad P_{\text{Lap}}(w \mid h) = \frac{C(h\,w) + 1}{C(h) + V}$$

V counts the types the model can predict: here 7, with </s> and <UNK> but not <s>.

Lesson: <UNK>, Laplace and add-k

Add-k

$$P(w \mid h) = \frac{C(h\,w) + k}{C(h) + kV}$$

A smaller k, such as 0.5 or 0.01, steals less from the seen words. Choose k on a dev set.

Lesson: <UNK>, Laplace and add-k

Absolute discounting Exam favourite

$$P(w \mid h) = \frac{\max(C(h\,w) - d,\, 0)}{C(h)} + \lambda(h)\, P(w), \quad \lambda(h) = \frac{d \cdot N_{1+}(h\,\bullet)}{C(h)}$$

Subtract a fixed d of about 0.75 from every seen count. N_{1+}(h •) is the number of different words seen after h.

Lesson: Better smoothing: discounting

Good-Turing

$$c^* = (c + 1)\,\frac{N_{c+1}}{N_c}, \quad P(\text{unseen}) = \frac{N_1}{N}$$

N_c = number of types seen exactly c times. Things seen once tell you how much is still unseen.

Lesson: Better smoothing: discounting

Witten-Bell

$$\lambda(h) = \frac{N_{1+}(h\,\bullet)}{N_{1+}(h\,\bullet) + C(h)}$$

A history followed by many different words is likely to be followed by a new one.

Lesson: Better smoothing: discounting

Kneser-Ney Exam favourite

$$P_{cont}(w) = \frac{|\{v : C(v\ w) > 0\}|}{\text{number of bigram types}}$$

Absolute discounting, but the lower order model counts how many different words come before w, not how often w occurs.

Lesson: Better smoothing: discounting

Backoff (Katz 1987)

$$P_{BO}(w \mid h) = P^*(w \mid h) \text{ if } C(h\ w) > 0, \text{ else } \alpha(h)\ P_{BO}(w \mid \text{shorter } h)$$

Non linear: use the highest order with evidence. P* is discounted and α hands exactly the freed mass to the lower order, so the result sums to 1.

Lesson: Backoff, interpolation and choosing λ

Linear interpolation Exam favourite

$$\hat{P}(w \mid h) = \lambda_3\, P(w \mid u\ v) + \lambda_2\, P(w \mid v) + \lambda_1\, P(w), \quad \Sigma\, \lambda = 1, \lambda \geq 0$$

Always mix all levels. Proof of normalisation: $\Sigma_w\, \hat{P} = \lambda_3 \cdot 1 + \lambda_2 \cdot 1 + \lambda_1 \cdot 1 = 1$.

Lesson: Backoff, interpolation and choosing λ

TABLES

Table: · out of vocabulary word · unseen n-gram of known words

	Out of vocabulary word	Unseen n-gram of known words
Example	"linguistics" was never seen at all	"am do": both words were seen, never together
Even the unigram is	0	fine
Fix	Map it to an <UNK> token	Smoothing, backoff or interpolation

Lesson: Two kinds of zero

Table: λ · 0.1 · 0.3 · 0.5

λ	0.1	0.3	0.5	0.7	0.9
dev PP	7.248	6.605	6.438	6.814	8.924

Lesson: Backoff, interpolation and choosing λ

TIPS AND TRAPS

COMMON MISTAKE The answer sheet got this one wrong twice. It wrote P(linguistics | like) = 0.01 instead of 1/10. Then it multiplied in the unigram values 0.034 and 0.207 in brackets, which is neither a Laplace bigram nor a proper backoff, and does not sum to 1. SRILM's vocabulary also contains <s> (its file lists 8 unigrams), so its add-one numbers can differ slightly. In the exam, state your V.

Lesson: <UNK>, Laplace and add-k

IN THE EXAM Chen and Goodman (1998) compared all of these. Modified Kneser-Ney with interpolation was the most accurate classic n-gram smoother, and it is still the default in toolkits such as KenLM. In assignment 2 it also won on the Brown corpus.

Lesson: Better smoothing: discounting

4.4 The SRILM toolkit and assignment 2

SRILM commands, count and ARPA files, test output, and the Brown corpus results of assignment 2.

KEY IDEAS

- **Workflow** ngram-count -write (counts), ngram-count -lm (model), ngram -lm -ppl -debug 2 (scores). Add -unk to map unknown words.

- **ARPA** $\log_{10}$ probabilities and backoff weights. −99 = log 0. Toy header ngram 1=8, ngram 2=14. $\log_{10}(5/22)$ = −0.6434527.
- **Default smoothing** Good-Turing with Katz backoff. Flags: -addsmooth k, -cdiscount, -wbdiscount, -kndiscount, -interpolate.
- **Brown results** Bigram ppl: add-one 2493, GT 642, WB 397, absolute 392, KN 352. Trigram lowers all except add-one.
- **Stop words and tuning** Removing punctuation and stop words raises ppl (397, 611, 3235), a trend only. Best k 0.001, λ 0.7, dev 581, test 681.

FORMULAS

Flags for smoothing

-addsmooth k, -cdiscount d, -wbdiscount, -kndiscount, -interpolate

Add-k, absolute discounting, Witten-Bell, Kneser-Ney, and making a method interpolated instead of backoff.

Lesson: SRILM in three commands

Default

no flag = Good-Turing discounting with Katz backoff

Heard as "good viewing" in the lecture recording.

Lesson: SRILM in three commands

TABLES

Table: step · command · what it does

Step	Command	What it does
1. Count	`ngram-count -text train.txt -order 2 -write train.count`	Writes every n-gram with its count
2. Estimate	`ngram-count -text train.txt -order 2 -lm train.lm -addsmooth 0`	Turns counts into probabilities and backoff weights, saved as an ARPA file
3. Test	`ngram -lm train.lm -ppl test.txt -debug 2`	Prints each word's probability, then logprob, ppl and ppl1

Lesson: SRILM in three commands

Table: arpa value · check by hand

ARPA value	Check by hand
−0.6434527 for I, Sam and </s>	$\log_{10}(5/22)$
−1.041393 for am and do	$\log_{10}(2/22)$
−0.8653014 for like	$\log_{10}(3/22)$
−0.2218488 for <s> Sam and Sam I	$\log_{10}(3/5)$
−0.1760913 for like </s>	$\log_{10}(2/3)$
−99 for <s>	The ARPA stand in for log 0. <s> is never predicted.

Lesson: SRILM in three commands

Table: srilm option · bigram ppl · bigram ppl1 · trigram ppl

SRILM option	Bigram ppl	Bigram ppl1	Trigram ppl	Trigram ppl1	$\log_{10}$ P(<unk>)
-addsmooth 1	2493.24	3600.57	3620.71	5321.27	−5.428
Absolute discounting	391.85	518.76	384.91	509.14	−1.401
Good-Turing	642.33	870.35	629.24	851.77	−5.408
Witten-Bell	396.83	525.66	385.06	509.35	−1.298
Kneser-Ney	352.45	464.28	340.18	447.38	−0.878

Lesson: Assignment 2, question by question

Table: data version · test words · model unigrams · ppl

Data version	Test words	Model unigrams	ppl	ppl1
Original	305,056	40,607	396.83	525.66
Punctuation tokens removed	268,236	40,590	610.78	859.35
Punctuation and stop words removed	148,503	40,262	3,234.52	7,019.32

Lesson: Assignment 2, question by question

Table: -addsmooth k · 1 · 0.1 · 0.01

-addsmooth k	1	0.1	0.01	0.001	0.0001
Best λ	0.3	0.6	0.7	0.7	0.6
Dev ppl	1123.66	833.51	656.01	581.03	582.25

Lesson: Assignment 2, question by question

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER If SRILM cannot be installed, NLTK's nltk.lm module (MLE, Laplace, KneserNeyInterpolated) reproduces the toy numbers. Check its padding and its token count for perplexity against SRILM's ppl and ppl1 before trusting it.

Lesson: SRILM in three commands

REMEMBER The professor asked students to do the coding activities with their own hands and not with a chatbot: "knowing is one thing, doing it with your hand is a different experience". The widgets in this chapter show the results so you can check yours, not replace them.

Lesson: From the toy corpus to the Brown corpus

STEP 5 Tagging and syntax

5.1 Part of speech tagging

The tagging task, tagsets, ambiguity, look up and backoff taggers, and generative against discriminative models.

KEY IDEAS

- **The task** Give each word its part of speech. Two cues: the word itself and its context. book: noun or verb. can: modal, noun or verb.
- **Tagsets** Traditional about 8, universal 12, UPOS 17, Penn Treebank 45, Brown about 87. More tags, harder but more informative.
- **Ambiguity numbers** About 11% of Brown types but 40% of tokens are ambiguous. Most frequent tag baseline about 92%, good taggers 97% and above.
- **Kinds of tagger** Look up with backoff, generative HMM (P(W, T)), discriminative MaxEnt, perceptron, CRF (P(T | W)), neural BiLSTM and BERT.
- **Generative and discriminative** argmax P(T | W) = argmax P(W, T) because P(W) is fixed. Not the same axis as supervised and unsupervised.

FORMULAS

The problem statement

Exam favourite

$$\text{given words } W = w_1 \dots w_n, \quad \text{find tags } \hat{T} = \operatorname{argmax}_T \mathrm{P}(T \mid W)$$

Supervised: train on sentences whose correct tags were added by linguists (a gold standard), then tag new sentences whose tags are hidden. It is classification into one of q tags, done for a whole sequence so the choices interact.

Lesson: What part of speech tagging is

Generative

Exam favourite

$$\hat{T} = \operatorname{argmax}_T \mathrm{P}(W, T) = \operatorname{argmax}_T \mathrm{P}(T) \cdot \mathrm{P}(W \mid T)$$

Learns how tag sequences go and which words each tag produces: a noun tends to produce student, dog, book. "A joint win for both parties."

Lesson: Generative or discriminative

Discriminative

Exam favourite

$$\hat{T} = \operatorname{argmax}_T \mathrm{P}(T \mid W)$$

Learns directly which tags fit these words in this context: reads in "The student reads books" is likely a verb.

Lesson: Generative or discriminative

TABLES

Table: sentence · word · tag · why

Sentence	Word	Tag	Why
I read a book	book	noun	a thing you read
Please book a ticket	book	verb	an action
She can dance	can	modal verb	ability
A can of soda	can	noun	a container
They can fish	can	verb (or modal)	they put fish in cans, or they are able to fish

Lesson: What part of speech tagging is

Table: input · british · left · waffles

Input	British	left	waffles	on	Falkland	Islands
Reading 1: the political Left is indecisive	N	N	V	P	N	N
Reading 2: British people left some waffles	N	V	N	P	N	N

Lesson: What part of speech tagging is

Table: tagset · tags · examples

Tagset	Tags	Examples
Traditional grammar	about 8	noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection
Universal (Petrov and colleagues, 2012)	12	NOUN, VERB, ADJ, ADV, PRON, DET, ADP, NUM, CONJ, PRT, ".", X
Universal Dependencies UPOS	17	adds PROPN, AUX, SCONJ, SYM, INTJ and others
Penn Treebank	45 (46 in NLTK's list)	NN, NNS, NNP, NNPS, VB, VBD, VBG, VBN, VBP, VBZ, JJ, JJR, JJS, ...
Brown corpus	about 87	even finer, with separate tags for forms of be and have

Lesson: How many tags are there?

Table: family · examples · idea

Family	Examples	Idea
Rule based and look up	Regular expression tagger, default tagger, unigram and bigram taggers in NLTK	Hand rules such as "-ing → VBG", or a table of the commonest tag, backing off when unseen
Statistical, generative	HMM tagger	Model P(W, T) = P(T) P(W | T): tags generate words. Decode with Viterbi.
Statistical, discriminative	Maximum entropy, perceptron, CRF	Model P(T | W) directly from rich features: prefix, suffix, capital letters, neighbouring words and tags
Neural	BiLSTM CRF, BERT, spaCy, Stanza	Learn dense embeddings and read context in both directions

Lesson: Kinds of tagger

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER Not every ambiguity is a tagging problem. In "The fisherman sat near the bank", bank is a noun in both readings, river bank and money bank. That is word sense ambiguity, a different task.

Lesson: What part of speech tagging is

REMEMBER Whatever tagger you use, do error analysis. Find where it fails, group the errors, then improve. The professor asked students to do activity 3 with their own hands, not with a chatbot: "You will only learn when you do it yourself."

Lesson: Kinds of tagger

5.2 Finite state machines and the HMM

FSAs, the HMM five tuple, the joint probability, validity checks, training by counting and enumeration.

KEY IDEAS

- **FSA** Five tuple (Q, Σ, q0, δ, F). Accept only if every symbol has an arrow and the machine ends in a final state. Sheep talk is /baa+!/.
- **HMM** Five tuple (Q, A, O, B, π). Tags are hidden, words are observed. A probabilistic Moore machine: states emit words.
- **Joint probability** P(W, T) = π(t1) b(w1 | t1) × product over i ≥ 2 of a(t(i−1) → ti) b(wi | ti). 2n factors. Markov and output independence assumptions.
- **Validity** Each row of A, each row of B and π sums to 1. A missing cell is 1 minus the rest of its row.
- **Training** Count starts, tag bigrams and (tag, word) pairs, then divide by row totals. Zeros need smoothing.

FORMULAS

The FSA five tuple Exam favourite

$$(Q, \Sigma, q_0, \delta, F)$$

Q is the set of states, Σ the alphabet of symbols, q_0 the start state, δ the transition function (state, symbol) → state, and F the final states, drawn as double circles.

Lesson: Finite state automata

The HMM five tuple Exam favourite

$$(Q, A, O, B, \pi)$$

Q the tag states, A the transition table P(tag | previous tag), O the vocabulary of words, B the emission table P(word | tag), π the start probabilities.

Lesson: The hidden Markov model

Joint probability of words and tags Exam favourite

$$P(W, T) = \pi(t_1)\, b_{t_1}(w_1) \prod_{i=2}^{n} a_{t_{i-1}t_i}\, b_{t_i}(w_i)$$

One start, n emissions and n − 1 transitions: 2n factors in all. "We multiply the transition probability with the emission probability" at every position.

Lesson: The hidden Markov model

Start

$$\pi(t) = \frac{\text{C(sentences starting with } t)}{\text{number of sentences}}$$

Lesson: Training an HMM is counting

Transition Exam favourite

$$a(t \to u) = \frac{\text{C}(t\ u)}{\text{C}(t \text{ followed by any tag})}$$

The tag bigram MLE.

Lesson: Training an HMM is counting

Emission Exam favourite

$$b(w \mid t) = \frac{\text{C}(w \text{ tagged } t)}{\text{C}(t)}$$

A unigram model of words for each tag.

Lesson: Training an HMM is counting

TABLES

Table: input · path · result · reason

Input	Path	Result	Reason
cat	q0 → q1 → q2 → q3	accept	ends in q3, a final state
car	q0 → q1 → q2 → q3	accept	the arrow q2 r q3 exists
ca	q0 → q1 → q2	reject	q2 is not final
cut	q0 → q1, stuck	reject	q1 has no arrow for u
cart	q0 → … → q3, stuck	reject	q3 has no arrow for t

Lesson: Finite state automata

Table: machine · output is attached to · in the hmm

Machine	Output is attached to	In the HMM
Mealy	each arrow (transition)	not used
Moore	each state	yes: a tag state emits a word

Lesson: The hidden Markov model

Table: · to a · to n · sum

	to A	to N	Sum
π (start)	1/2	1/2	1
from A	1/3	2/3	1
from N	1/10	9/10	1

Lesson: Is this HMM valid?

Table: emits · crazy · killer · clown

Emits	crazy	killer	clown	problem	Sum
A	1	0	0	0	1
N	0	1/3	1/3	1/3	1

Lesson: Is this HMM valid?

Table: tags · π · b(killer) · a · b(clown) · p(w, t)

Tags	π · b(killer) · a · b(clown)	P(W, T)
A A	0.25 × 0 × 0 × 0	0
A N	0.25 × 0 × 1.0 × 0.4	0
N A	0.75 × 0.3 × 0.5 × 0	0
N N	0.75 × 0.3 × 0.5 × 0.4	**0.045**

Lesson: Scoring every tag sequence

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER How does this help with language? Finite state machines run tokenisers, regular expression taggers, spelling checkers and morphology (leaves maps to leaf + N + PL). Put probabilities on the arrows and you get a Markov chain, the n-gram model of step 4. Let each state also emit a word and you get the HMM.

Lesson: Finite state automata

COMMON MISTAKE Do not confuse an HMM with a bigram word model. In the bigram model the thing you condition on, the previous word, is visible. In the HMM it is a hidden tag, so to find tags you must search (Viterbi) or sum (forward) over them.

Lesson: The hidden Markov model

IN THE EXAM Exam questions often hide one cell. Fill it with 1 minus the rest of its row (problem G2). The rows are what sum to 1, never the columns: P(N | A) + P(N | N) = 2/3 + 9/10 is not 1 and does not need to be.

Lesson: Is this HMM valid?

COMMON MISTAKE Two different killer clown HMMs appear in the deck. Slides 23 and 24 give P(killer clown, N N) = 1/2 × 1/3 × 9/10 × 1/3 = 0.05. Slide 27 gives 0.045. Same winner, different number. Always use the tables the question gives you (problem G4).

Lesson: Scoring every tag sequence

5.3 Decoding with Viterbi

Brute force against dynamic programming, the Viterbi and forward recursions, posteriors, ties and trigram HMMs.

KEY IDEAS

- **Search size** Brute force scores q^T sequences. Viterbi does about T × q² steps. PTB 45 tags, 25 words: 2.1 × 10^41 against 50,625.
- **Viterbi recursion** v1(j) = πj bj(w1). vt(j) = max over i of vt−1(i) aij bj(wt). Keep back pointers, take the best last cell and trace back.
- **Forward** Same table with sum: P(W) = sum of the last column. Posterior P(T | W) = P(W, T) ÷ P(W). they can fish: 0.073164 and 0.7233.
- **Why it works** Principle of optimality: under the Markov assumption the best path passes through the best partial path into each cell.
- **Ties and trigrams** Ties: pick either, or return k best. Trigram HMM (TnT): O(T q³), needs smoothing, about 96.7% on PTB.

FORMULAS

The decoding objective

Exam favourite

$$\hat{T} = \operatorname{argmax}_{t_1 \ldots t_n} \prod_i P(w_i \mid t_i) \cdot P(t_i \mid t_{i-1})$$

The first factor is the emission, the second the transition. $P(t_1 \mid t_0)$ means the start probability $\pi(t_1)$.

Lesson: Why brute force fails

Viterbi recursion

Exam favourite

$$v_1(j) = \pi_j \, b_j(w_1) \qquad v_t(j) = \max_i v_{t-1}(i) \cdot a_{ij} \cdot b_j(w_t)$$

$v_t(j)$ is the probability of the best tag path that ends in tag j after reading t words. Store the winning i as a back pointer.

Lesson: The Viterbi algorithm

Cost

$$O(T \cdot q^2) \text{ time}, \quad O(T \cdot q) \text{ memory}$$

For each of T positions and q tags, compare q predecessors.

Lesson: The Viterbi algorithm

Forward recursion

Exam favourite

$$\alpha_1(j) = \pi_j \, b_j(w_1) \qquad \alpha_t(j) = \Sigma_i \, \alpha_{t-1}(i) \cdot a_{ij} \cdot b_j(w_t)$$

$\alpha_t(j)$ is the total probability of the first t words with tag j at position t.

Lesson: The forward algorithm and confidence

Sentence probability and posterior

$$P(W) = \Sigma_j \, \alpha_T(j) \qquad P(T \mid W) = \frac{P(W, T)}{P(W)}$$

The posterior says how sure the model is of one tagging.

Lesson: The forward algorithm and confidence

Second order HMM

$$P(t_i \mid t_{i-2}, t_{i-1}) \qquad \text{cost } O(T \cdot q^3)$$

Viterbi now runs over pairs of tags. There are q^3 transition parameters instead of q^2, so sparsity grows and interpolation is needed, exactly as for trigram language models.

Lesson: Ties, trigrams and real taggers

TABLES

Table: q (tags) · t (words) · sequences q t · viterbi steps t × q²

q (tags)	T (words)	Sequences q^T	Viterbi steps T × q²
2	4	16	16
12	10	6.19×10^{10}	1,440
45	25	2.14×10^{41}	50,625
87	10	2.48×10^{19}	75,690

Lesson: Why brute force fails

Table: π · n 0.7 · m 0.1 · v 0.2

π	N 0.7	M 0.1	V 0.2

Lesson: The Viterbi algorithm

Table: a (from ↓, to →) · n · m · v

A (from ↓, to →)	N	M	V
N	0.2	0.4	0.4
M	0.1	0	0.9
V	0.6	0.1	0.3

Lesson: The Viterbi algorithm

Table: b · they · can · fish

B	they	can	fish
N	0.3	0.2	0.5
M	0	1.0	0
V	0	0.3	0.7

Lesson: The Viterbi algorithm

Table: tags · p(w, t) · p(t | w)

Tags	P(W, T)	P(T | W)
N M V	0.052920	0.7233
N V N	0.007560	0.1033
N V V	0.005292	0.0723
N M N	0.004200	0.0574
N N V	0.002352	0.0321
N N N	0.000840	0.0115

Lesson: The forward algorithm and confidence

TIPS AND TRAPS

IN THE EXAM

Exam recipe. 1: write π, A and B as tables and check the rows. 2: if T ≤ 3 and q ≤ 2, enumerating all paths is fine, show every product. 3: otherwise fill a q × T table column by column, writing the winning predecessor in each cell. 4: back trace from the best last cell. 5: state the tag sequence and its probability. Strike out zero emissions first.

Lesson: The Viterbi algorithm

5.4 Chunking and named entities

Chunks, regex chunkers, IOB and BIOES encoding, NER models and entity level F1.

KEY IDEAS

- **Chunk** A flat, non overlapping group of words such as [the yellow dog]. Chunking is shallow parsing. Constituents nest, chunks do not.
- **IOB** B-X begins, I-X continues, O is outside. 2k + 1 labels. Turns span finding into tagging with the same models.
- **Decoding IOB** A span is a B-X plus the following I-X tags. An I-X after O or another type is repaired as B-X.
- **NER** PER, ORG, LOC, DATE, MONEY. Perceptron, CRF, BiLSTM CRF and BERT. Features: capitals, shape, gazetteers, neighbours.
- **Scoring** Entity level precision, recall and F1 with exact start, end and type. Token accuracy is inflated by O.

FORMULAS

IOB tags Exam favourite

$\mathbf{B}\text{-}X$ begins a chunk of type X $\mathbf{I}\text{-}X$ is inside it $\mathbf{O}$ is outside every chunk

With k chunk types there are 2k + 1 labels. The input can be the words and their POS tags.

Lesson: IOB: spans as tags

Entity level F1 Exam favourite

$$P = \frac{\text{correct spans}}{\text{predicted spans}} \quad R = \frac{\text{correct spans}}{\text{gold spans}} \quad F1 = \frac{2PR}{P + R}$$

A predicted span counts only if its start, end and type all match. Token accuracy is misleading because most tokens are O.

Lesson: Named entity tagging

TABLES

Table: · chunk · constituent

	Chunk	Constituent
Shape	flat, never nested	nested inside a full tree
Example	[the yellow dog]	[[the yellow dog] [in [the park]]]
Defined by	any useful group, often base noun and verb phrases	grammar: noun phrase, verb phrase, adjective phrase
Cost	fast and robust, a tagging problem	slower, needs a parser (chapter 5.5)

Lesson: What a chunk is

Table: type · examples

Type	Examples
PER (person)	Sidharth Ranjan, Marie Curie
ORG (organisation)	United, IIT Jodhpur, the World Health Organization
LOC or GPE (place)	San Francisco, the Falkland Islands, India
DATE, MONEY, PERCENT	next Tuesday, 500 rupees, 12%

Lesson: Named entity tagging

TIPS AND TRAPS

REMEMBER This is why POS tagging comes first. The chunker never looks at the words, only at the tags, so tagging errors flow straight into chunking errors.

Lesson: What a chunk is

REMEMBER Why B at all? Two chunks of the same type can sit side by side: "gave [the girl] [a book]". With only I and O, the girl a book would merge into one span. B marks where the second one starts.

Lesson: IOB: spans as tags

5.5 Constituency and dependency syntax

Constituency tests, CFGs, dependency trees, PCFGs, attachment ambiguity and Catalan growth.

KEY IDEAS

- **Constituents** Groups that act as one unit. Tests: movement, substitution by a pro form, fragment answer, coordination, clefting.
- **CFG** Four tuple (N, Σ, R, S). Rules A → β. Bracket notation stores trees. Penn Treebank supplies trees and rule counts.

- **Dependencies** Head → dependent arcs with labels (nsubj, obj, det). A tree: one head per word, n arcs with ROOT, no cycles. UD makes content words heads.
- **PCFG** P(tree) = product of rule probabilities, rules for each non terminal sum to 1. Elephant: VP attach 0.01575 against 0.0105, ratio 1.5.
- **Ambiguity growth** k PPs give Catalan C(k + 1) parses: 2, 5, 14, 42. CKY parses in O(n³).

FORMULAS

Bracket notation

Exam favourite

$$(S\ (NP\ (N\ Fed))\ (VP\ (V\ raises)\ (NP\ (N\ interest)\ (N\ rates))))$$

Each opening bracket starts a node and names its label. Treebanks store trees this way, on one line, called a linearised tree.

Lesson: Constituents and phrase structure

CFG four tuple

Exam favourite

$$(N, \Sigma, R, S)$$

N non terminals (S, NP, VP ...), Σ terminals (the words), R rules of the form A → β, and the start symbol S. A sentence is grammatical if S can be rewritten into it, and the rewriting history is its parse tree.

Lesson: Context free grammars

Probabilistic CFG

Exam favourite

$$P(\text{tree}) = \prod_{\text{rules } A \to \beta \text{ used}} P(\beta \mid A), \quad \text{with } \Sigma_\beta\, P(\beta \mid A) = 1 \text{ for each A}$$

Rule probabilities come from treebank counts: P(VP → V NP) = C(VP → V NP) ÷ C(VP). Choose the tree with the higher product.

Lesson: Attachment ambiguity and PCFGs

Catalan growth

$$C_n = \frac{(2n)!}{(n+1)!\,n!} \quad \text{parses with } k \text{ PPs} = C_{k+1}\text{: } 2, 5, 14, 42, 132 \ldots$$

Exponential growth, just like tag sequences. Chart parsers (CKY) share sub trees in O(n³) time.

Lesson: Attachment ambiguity and PCFGs

TABLES

Table: test · what you do · "about drugs" in "john talked to the children about drugs"

Test	What you do	"about drugs" in "John talked to the children about drugs"
Movement	Move the group as a block	John talked [about drugs] [to the children]: fine
Fragment answer	Use it alone as an answer	What did John talk about? About drugs.
Substitution	Replace it with a pro form (it, there, did so)	John talked to the children about it.
Coordination	Join it with a similar group	about drugs and about school
Clefting	"It was X that ..."	It was about drugs that John talked to the children.

Lesson: Constituents and phrase structure

Table: rule · reads as

Rule	Reads as
S → NP VP	a sentence is a noun phrase followed by a verb phrase
NP → Det N	a noun phrase can be a determiner and a noun
VP → V NP | V	a verb phrase is a verb with or without an object
Det → the, N → dog | cat, V → chased | slept	the lexicon: which words fill each slot

Lesson: Context free grammars

Table: kind · labels · meaning

Kind	Labels	Meaning
Argument	nsubj, obj, iobj	the participants the verb needs: who paints, what is painted, to whom
Modifier	det, amod, nmod, advmod	optional extras: determiners, adjectives, noun and adverb modifiers

Lesson: Dependency structure

Table: · dependency structure · phrase structure

	Dependency structure	Phrase structure
Shows	head to dependent relations, with function labels	nested phrases with category labels (NP, VP)
Nodes	only the words	words plus phrase nodes
Good for	free word order, relation extraction, who did what to whom	phrase boundaries, coordination, grammar engineering
Treebank	Universal Dependencies, 100+ languages	Penn Treebank

Lesson: Dependency structure

Table: tool · what it gives you

Tool	What it gives you
NLTK	corpora (Brown, Penn Treebank sample), n-gram and perceptron taggers, chunkers, CFG and PCFG parsers
spaCy	fast pipelines: tokens, POS, lemmas, dependency parse, named entities
Stanza	neural pipeline for 60+ languages with UPOS, XPOS, UD dependency parsing and NER

Lesson: Attachment ambiguity and PCFGs

TIPS AND TRAPS

IN THE EXAM — A student asked whether this is a DAG, as in compilers. It is stricter: a tree. Every word has exactly one head, there are no cycles, and a sentence of n words has exactly n arcs counting the ROOT arc.

Lesson: Dependency structure

REMEMBER — In spaCy, every token knows its text, t.pos_, t.dep_ and t.head.text. Running it on the elephant sentence shows which attachment the trained parser picked.

Lesson: Attachment ambiguity and PCFGs

STEP 6 Exam revision

6.1 Exam revision: from school to research universities

Exam style questions from school level to research universities, with worked answers, a formula sheet and a mock quiz.

FORMULAS

Type token ratio — Exam favourite

$$\text{TTR} = \frac{\text{number of types}}{\text{number of tokens}}$$

Types are distinct words. Tokens are running words.

Lesson: Tier 1: school and first year

Zipf's law — Exam favourite

$$f \times r \approx C$$

The word of rank r appears about C ÷ r times.

Lesson: Tier 1: school and first year

Entropy

$$H = -\Sigma\, p \log_2 p$$

Average surprise in bits. A fair coin has 1 bit.

Lesson: Tier 1: school and first year

TABLES

Table: tier · typical format · what earns the marks · where to practise

Tier	Typical format	What earns the marks	Where to practise
School and first year	Short answers, counting, small probabilities	Clear definitions with an example, careful counting	Lesson 2
University semester and IIT course exams	Numericals by hand, short notes, compare and contrast	Formula first, every step shown, the final answer stated with its meaning	Lesson 3
NPTEL and GATE style papers	Multiple choice, multiple select and numerical answer type, no partial credit	Speed, recognising the trap option, exact rounding	Lesson 4
MIT, Stanford and Cambridge style	Derivations, proofs, design and critique	Assumptions named, a complete argument, when it breaks	Lesson 5

Lesson: How NLP is examined

Table: training corpus

Training corpus
<s> I am Sam </s>
<s> Sam I am </s>
<s> Sam I like </s>
<s> Sam I do like </s>
<s> do I like Sam </s>

Lesson: Tier 2: university semester and IIT course exams

Table: shortcut · use it for

Shortcut	Use it for
Uniform over k outcomes: H = $\log_2$ k, PP = k	Instant entropy and perplexity of a uniform model
PP = 2^H = $10^{-\log 10\ P \div N}$	Switching between bits and SRILM's base 10
n-gram table size V^n	Why trigrams are sparse
IOB labels 2k + 1, BIOES 4k + 1	Label counts for k entity types
Brute force q^T, Viterbi T q^2, trigram HMM T q^3	Complexity questions
Dependency tree: n words, n arcs with ROOT	Counting arcs
KL ≥ 0, equal to 0 only when P = Q	True or false on divergences
H(X, Y) = H(X) + H(Y | X)	Chain rule for entropy

Lesson: Tier 3: multiple choice and numerical answer papers

Table: topic · formula

Topic	Formula
Zipf	$f \times r \approx C$
Surprisal, entropy	$I(x) = -\log_2 p(x)$, $H = -\Sigma\, p \log_2 p$
Conditional entropy, chain rule	$H(Y \mid X) = H(X, Y) - H(X)$
Mutual information	$I(X : Y) = H(X) - H(X \mid Y)$, $PMI = \log_2 P(x, y) \div P(x)\, P(y)$
KL, cross entropy	$KL(P \parallel Q) = \Sigma\, P \log_2(P \div Q)$, $H(P, Q) = H(P) + KL$
Bigram MLE	$P(w \mid h) = C(h\ w) \div C(h)$
Laplace, add-k	$(C(h\ w) + 1) \div (C(h) + V)$, $(C(h\ w) + k) \div (C(h) + kV)$
Interpolation	$\lambda_3 P(w \mid u\ v) + \lambda_2 P(w \mid v) + \lambda_1 P(w)$, λs sum to 1
Perplexity	$P^{-1/N} = 2^H$, SRILM $ppl = 10^{-lp \div (words - OOV + sents)}$
HMM joint	$\pi(t_1)\, b(w_1 \mid t_1) \prod a(t_{i-1} \to t_i)\, b(w_i \mid t_i)$
Viterbi, forward	$v_t(j) = \max_i v_{t-1}(i)\, a_{ij}\, b_j(w_t)$, α with Σ
Entity F1	$2PR \div (P + R)$ on exact spans
PCFG	$P(tree) = \prod P(rule)$
Catalan	$C_n = (2n)! \div ((n + 1)!\, n!)$

Lesson: Formula sheet and last minute checks

TIPS AND TRAPS

COMMON MISTAKE Do not mix tokens and types. "How many words" is ambiguous in an exam. Say which you counted.

Lesson: Tier 1: school and first year

COMMON MISTAKE State your convention for <s> and </s> before computing. Counting </s> as a predicted token changes both the probability and the N in perplexity.

Lesson: Tier 2: university semester and IIT course exams

IN THE EXAM Trap options to expect: counting <s> as a predicted token, mixing log base 2 and 10, forgetting to add V in the Laplace denominator, treating columns of an HMM table as summing to 1, and calling a chunk a constituent.

Lesson: Tier 3: multiple choice and numerical answer papers

IN THE EXAM In derivations, name each assumption when you use it: Markov, output independence, a fixed vocabulary, independent sentences. Examiners often ask what breaks when one fails.

Lesson: Tier 4: derivations, design and critique